

Analyze, Don't Just Summarize

Study Guide - Extended Response

1. Learning goal

Explain why evidence matters and evaluate the reasoning that connects evidence to a source's conclusion.

2. What this skill means

Summary tells the reader what the source says. Analysis tells the reader why that evidence makes the argument stronger or weaker. Strong ER body paragraphs repeatedly answer: What does this evidence show? Why is it relevant? How does it compare with the other source?

3. Do not confuse it with

"Source A says sales rose 20 percent" is summary. "The 20 percent increase directly measures the outcome Source A claims the policy improves" is analysis.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask which sentence best analyzes evidence, identifies an assumption, or compares the reasoning in two sources.

5. Repeatable method

- State one evaluative point.
- Give specific evidence.
- Explain why the evidence supports or weakens the claim.
- Identify any reasoning gap, assumption, or limitation.
- Compare with the other source when the comparison sharpens the judgment.

6. Worked example

Source B uses one cafe patio to recommend shade sails for an entire district.

Question: What is the reasoning issue?

Reasoning: The conclusion covers a much larger area than the evidence. The source assumes one location is representative.

Best answer: The evidence scope is too narrow for the district-wide conclusion.

7. Common traps

- Restating a statistic and calling it analysis.
- Using "This proves" without explaining the connection.
- Attacking the author instead of the reasoning.
- Ignoring a valid point in the weaker source.

8. Diagnostic help

- After every evidence sentence, add "This matters because..." and make the reason specific.
- If your paragraph contains many source details but few because/therefore/ comparison sentences, you may be summarizing.
- If you call a source weak, name the exact missing link: relevance, sufficiency, assumption, or unsupported prediction.

9. Quick check

Source A measures eight blocks; Source B gives one patio example for a district-wide recommendation.

Write one analysis sentence.

Check yourself: Source A is more persuasive on scope because its evidence covers several locations, while Source B generalizes from one example.